

P1 Dust of Snow

For Reference

Question 1.

What is a “dust of snow”? What does the poet say has changed his mood? How has the poet’s mood changed?

Answer:

The ‘dust of snow’ refers to tiny snowflakes that fell on the poet from a hemlock tree.. The poet’s mood changed from sad to happy. He felt refreshed and wanted to enjoy the rest of the day.

Question 2.

How does Frost present nature in this poem? The following questions may help you to think of an answer.

- a) What are the birds that are usually named in poems? Do you think crow is often mentioned in poems? What images come to your mind when you think of a crow?

Ans: Generally, poets take the birds and trees which are known for their beauty and good qualities like peacock, parrot, cuckoo, mynah and trees full of beautiful flowers and fruits. But here Frost has taken a totally different approach. He chose a crow, which is not often used in poems. Crow is black in colour with very harsh voice and is believed to be a symbol of bad omen. Thinking of a crow brings very depressing and sorrowful pictures to our mind.

- b) Again, what is ‘a hemlock tree’? Why doesn’t the poet write about more ‘beautiful’ tree such as a maple, or an oak, or a pine?

Ans: A hemlock tree is poisonous plant with small white flowers. The poet, Robert Frost, deliberately avoids writing about beautiful trees like an oak or maple to emphasise the transformative power of seemingly unpleasant elements in nature.

- c) What do the ‘crow’ and ‘hemlock’ represent-joy or sorrow? What does the dust of snow that the crow shakes off a hemlock tree stand for?

Ans: The crow and hemlock tree represent sorrow and negativity. However, the dust of snow that the crow shakes off a hemlock tree symbolizes positivity and hope showing how small, unexpected moments can uplift one’s mood.

3. How does a simple incident in the poem convey a significant idea?

Ans: The poem "Dust of Snow" by Robert Frost is a small poem consisting of just eight lines that narrate a simple incident. The poet narrates how one day he was in a depressed, dejected

mood and had spent a large part of the day with his mind sunken in melancholy. But, by chance he passed by a snow covered hemlock tree. A crow sitting on the tree moved and as a result some snow fell on the poet. This small chance happening had a deep impact on the poet's mind. He was at once transported from a depressed state of mind to that of delight and happiness. His mind was relieved of the burden of melancholy.

The seemingly insignificant event, in this way, proved to be so effective that it absolutely changed the poet's mood and state of mind. Moreover, it left an important message that sometimes trivial happenings may have a deep, serious significance. Such incidents are sometimes forceful enough to bring about a drastic change in the life of a person. Even a bird like a crow sitting on a poisonous tree covered with snow can be instrumental in bringing about a profound change in the attitude of a person. A small incident can reveal how one feels relieved of the worldly burdens in the lap of nature. Even the so-called harsh and frosty aspects of nature can impart solace and delight.